Ke Cheng HSU (Clio)
Department of Economics, The Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
Clear Water Bay, Kowloon, Hong Kong · +852 6840 9753
khsu@connect.ust.hk · cliohsu1997.github.io

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Faculty Search Committee
Glorious Sun School of Economics and Management, Donghua University
zhoulili@dhu.edu.cn

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to apply for the tenure-track Lecturer position in Industrial Economics at the Glorious Sun School of Economics and Management, Donghua University. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology. I expect to graduate in June 2027 and can join in Fall 2027. My research fields are Empirical Industrial Organization and Digital Economics. My undergraduate degree is in Mathematics and Economics.

My job market paper, "Designing Return Policy in E-Commerce: A Trade-off between Purchase and Return Efficiency," studies whether a return policy encourages efficient returns and purchases. A stricter policy curbs inefficient returns after delivery, but the lower return rate makes a higher product price more attractive for the seller and can exclude efficient purchases. Using transaction data from a Taobao apparel retailer, I estimate a structural model of purchase, return-shipping insurance, and return decisions under monopoly pricing across six categories. Automatic coverage of return shipping performs better when the margin, net scrap value, and uncertainty are high, because it expands efficient purchases. Optional coverage performs better when those attributes are low, because it curbs excessive returns. A menu that pairs a discounted price with a medium restocking fee balances the two margins and performs better than both insurance policies for most categories.

A second paper, "Product Design with Heterogeneous Search Costs" (with Pak Hung Au), studies how firms use product design to direct the search of consumers with different search costs. In two ongoing projects, with Kohei Kawaguchi and Kei Kawai, I use Japanese bookstore data to study how resale price maintenance encourages retailers to hold inventory in low-demand states, yet leaves unsold copies that cannot be cleared by cutting the price and are returned. With Ce Bian and Liang Zhao, I study pass-through when products can be returned, and show that a tax can lower the equilibrium price and raise welfare by reducing the return rate.

At HKUST I was a teaching assistant from 2020 to 2025 for undergraduate macroeconomics, the economics of uncertainty and information, and Ph.D. microeconomic theory, with an average evaluation of 4.72/5. In 2026 I designed and lectured the mathematics camp for the MSc in Economics, receiving 4.53/5. I can teach industrial organization, econometrics, and microeconomic theory, including core courses and courses that use structural methods and transaction data.

I attach my curriculum vitae and the two papers named above. You can reach me at khsu@connect.ust.hk or +852 6840 9753.

Sincerely,

Ke Cheng HSU
Ph.D. Candidate, Department of Economics, HKUST